

Genuine Stall vs Smoke.

The Reversible Yes.

Not every delay is a no. The reversible yes lets you tell which is which — and moves the real ones forward today.

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Genuine stall vs smoke.

Real stalls have specific details, named third parties, and booked-in next steps. Smoke has none of those.

GENUINE STALL · REAL

- Specific reason with personal or operational detail.
- Names a real third party (accountant, partner, family).
- Booked-in callback with a date and time.
- Buyer initiates the next step or confirms it actively.
- Energy stays warm — engagement still there.
- Buyer still asks follow-up questions.

WHAT IT SOUNDS LIKE:

"My installer's brother passed away — Monday's a write-off. Can you call me Wednesday after I see the accountant?"

SMOKE · POLITE DELAY

- Vague reason. Generic timing language.
- References an unnamed "someone" who needs to weigh in.
- No fixed callback time — "I'll get back to you."
- Rep has to initiate every follow-up.
- Energy flattens — engagement collapses.
- Buyer stops asking questions.

WHAT IT SOUNDS LIKE:

"Let me have a think about it — I'll get back to you when I've had a chance to chat to the team."

THE RULE

Genuine stalls earn the wait. Smoke doesn't. Use the reversible yes (page 4) to find out which one you're dealing with.

The diagnostic question.

Before you accept the stall — ask the one question that surfaces the buyer's real lean.

THE QUESTION

"Just out of interest — which one are you more likely to go for?"

WHY THE PHRASING MATTERS

01 "Just out of interest" disarms the buyer

The opener signals informal curiosity, not a sales push. The buyer can answer without feeling cornered into committing.

02 It surfaces a lean — not a decision

The question asks which they're more likely to choose, not which they choose. Buyers answer more honestly when the stakes are lower.

03 It builds the foundation for the next move

Without this answer, the rep has to guess where to apply pressure. With it, the rep knows whether to mirror the up-front path or the monthly path.

04 It tests the stall while accepting it

Asking this question costs nothing if the buyer's stall is genuine — and reveals everything if it isn't.

Mirror the preference. Offer the reversible yes.

Once the buyer has named a lean, mirror it back and offer a small path forward they can reverse.

MIRROR

01

"I'd just go up-front too, honestly." Acknowledge their lean. Validate the choice.

VALIDATE

02

"You're already spending \$2,000 a month with the other crew. This is only \$5,000 once."

OFFER THE REVERSIBLE PATH

03

"Why don't we just get a small deposit down to get the ball rolling?"

REMOVE THE LOCK-IN FEAR

04

"If you change your mind after the accountant call, we'll just swap it out — same product either way."

WHY THE REVERSIBLE YES UNLOCKS THE STALL

Most buyers who hesitate aren't hesitating about the product — they're hesitating about commitment. Reversibility lowers the perceived cost of yes. The buyer is choosing the next step, not the destination — which is much easier to say yes to.

The smoke detector.

What the buyer does after you offer reversibility tells you everything. Each reaction has a different read.

BUYER TAKES THE DEPOSIT

Genuine interest. The deal moves forward.

REAL

BUYER ENTHUSIASTICALLY AGREES BUT "WILL SORT IT TOMORROW"

Soft smoke. Follow up tomorrow but expect attrition.

SOFT SMOKE

BUYER FINDS A NEW REASON TO DELAY DESPITE REVERSIBILITY

Hard smoke. Deal was never going to close at this price or in this window.

HARD SMOKE

BUYER ASKS A GENUINE QUESTION ABOUT DEPOSIT MECHANICS

Still real, just needs information. Answer and re-offer the path.

REAL

THE PRINCIPLE

Each reaction is information. Real interest survives the test. Smoke reveals itself the moment reversibility removes the lock-in fear.

Daily reference card.

Print and pin. Read before every stalled deal.

DO · ON EVERY STALL

- Listen for specific reasons + named third parties.
- Ask the diagnostic question casually.
- Mirror the buyer's stated preference.
- Offer the small-deposit reversible path.
- Frame reversibility explicitly: "we can swap it."
- Accept genuine stalls — book the callback.
- Apply urgency to the booked-in callback.
- Read each reaction as information.

DON'T · EVER

- Don't accept every stall at face value.
- Don't push a buyer who's named a real personal reason.
- Don't ask "are you ready to commit?" — too binary.
- Don't offer the reversible yes without first asking the diagnostic.
- Don't lock the buyer into something that can't be changed.
- Don't treat soft smoke as a real deal in the pipeline.
- Don't follow up endlessly on hard smoke.
- Don't conflate two distinct concerns into one objection.

WATCH-OUTS

- Buyer who can't name the third party they need to consult.
- Buyer who won't set a specific callback time.
- New reasons appearing after each one is addressed.
- Energy collapse during the diagnostic question.
- "I need to think about it" with no anchor.
- Buyer agreeing enthusiastically but "tomorrow."
- Soft yeses with no path forward.
- Forgetting that real stalls deserve real urgency on the callback.

THE ONE-LINER

Real stalls earn the wait. Smoke doesn't. The reversible yes tells you which.